

Reforming research assessment at Health Sciences University (UK): CoARA action plan 2024–2026

Introduction to CoARA

As part of the increasing interest in improving research cultures, there is a growing global movement to reform research assessment to maximise the quality and impact of research. The Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) was established in 2022/23 to provide a platform for organisations across the world to work collectively to ensure that the assessment of research, researchers and research organisations recognises the diverse outputs, practices and activities that maximise the quality and impact of research. This requires basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgement, for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.

The CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment is based on ten commitments that seek to establish a common direction for research assessment reform, while respecting organisations' autonomy. The Agreement sets a shared direction for changes in assessment practices for research, researchers and research performing organisations, with the overarching goal to maximise the quality and impact of research. The Agreement includes the principles, commitments, and timeframe for reforms and lays out the principles for a Coalition of organisations willing to work together in implementing the changes.

Hundreds of organisations globally have already signed the Agreement. In the UK, 18 universities have signed it to date, alongside organisations and groups including UK Research & Innovation (UKRI), JISC, the UK Research Integrity Office (UKRIO), the Association of Research Manager & Administrators, the Wellcome Trust, Health Data Research UK, and the UK Reproducibility Network. A full list of signatories is available here: <https://coara.eu/agreement/signatories/>.

Introduction to CoARA at Health Sciences University

In April 2024, Health Sciences University (HSU) became a signatory of CoARA. We committed to developing our CoARA action plan within 12 months of signing the Agreement and are delighted to share this version publicly to demonstrate how we plan to align our policies, procedures and practices to the CoARA commitments. In summer 2024, we established the HSU CoARA Working Group to guide the university in aligning research assessment practices with the CoARA Agreement. This includes developing, implementing, and overseeing plans, policies, and improvements to ensure the university adheres to the CoARA commitments. The CoARA Working Group has also assumed the role of the core team for HSU's CoARA Cascade Boost project, for which an award was made in October 2024. The CoARA Working Group reports to the HSU Research & Innovation Committee, which is overseen by the HSU Academic Board.

This action plan was developed by the CoARA Working Group, with input from staff and postgraduate research students. Drafts were presented to the Research & Innovation Committee in January and March 2025, when the Committee formally approved the action plan.

The CoARA Working Group is chaired by the Head of Research. Members include: Head of People and Development, Library Services Manager, School & Centre Research Leads, Professor of Musculoskeletal Health & Care, Research & Knowledge Exchange Manager, Early Career Researcher representative, and Postgraduate Research Student representative.

The CoARA commitments

By signing the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment, the university subscribes to four Core Commitments and six Supporting Commitments. These are:

Core Commitments

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

Supporting Commitments

5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

CoARA Cascade Boost Project

In October 2024, we received confirmation that HSU had been awarded an Institutional Pilot Project through the first round of the CoARA Cascade Boost call (funded by the EU). Our project is titled: Catalysing research assessment reform in a small and specialist university: Reimagining our Academic Framework and evaluating its implementation in a revised academic performance review exercise. The project's mission is to raise awareness of the importance of research assessment reform (RAR) across the university, ensure our staff are upskilled in the latest innovations in academic career assessment (ACA), actively engage a diverse group of staff in RAR (including researchers at all career levels), and accelerate the pace of institutional change at our university. Through the project, we are revising our Academic Framework (AF) and associated criteria, tools and procedures and will test this the annual performance review exercise in 2025. An evaluation will take place of their efficacy, after which we will seek to embed them in other ACA activities, e.g. recruitment and promotion.

The project objectives are to:

- Develop the AF to recognise a broader and more diverse range of contributions, activities and behaviours (including open science).
- Evaluate existing and design new tools and procedures to implement the revised AF criteria in the annual performance review exercise, ensuring qualitative judgement at the heart of the process.
- Eradicate inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics.
- Provide training and development to upskill staff.
- Design and implement an engagement and communication plan to raise internal awareness of CoARA, DORA and RAR.
- Widely promote and discuss lessons learned.



Monitoring the action plan

The CoARA Working Group will meet frequently to progress the CoARA work at HSU. Our action plan is a living document and will be updated regularly. Progress will be reported formally to the Research & Innovation Committee on an annual basis.

Queries

Any queries about the HSU CoARA action plan should be directed in the first instance to: research@aecc.ac.uk.

No.	Commitment	Action	Part of CoARA award	Responsibility	Start	End
1	Core commitment: Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers, in research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.	1.1 Develop and publish a HSU Gender Equality Plan adhering to the Horizon Europe Gender Equality Plan guidance.	Partially	Head of Research and Head of People & Development	Dec-24	Jul-25
		1.2 Develop and embed a HSU Policy on Responsible Research Metrics.		Head of Research	Dec-24	Jul-25
		1.3 Explore the UK Technician's Commitment and consider how it could be embedded at HSU.		Head of People & Development	Apr-26	Jul-26
		1.4 Review the matrix in the Academic Framework to ensure it recognises a diverse and broad range of research contributions.	Partially	CoARA Working Group	Jan-25	Jan-26
		1.5 Explore opportunities to use the new HSU research repository to capture contributions to outputs.		Library Services Manager	Jan-25	Jul-25
		1.6 Review and update the HSU PGR Student Handbook, PGR annual monitoring process, induction, and guidance for supervisory teams to ensure alignment to CoARA.		Head of Research, Research & KE Manager, and PGR CoARA rep	Apr-25	Jul-25
2	Core commitment: Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.	2.1 After the first REF review exercise, evaluate HSU REF preparation framework and assessment processes to ensure that peer review and qualitative evaluation were the core assessment practices for the REF review exercises.		REF Working Group	Sep-25	Apr-26
		2.2 Deliver training for internal REF reviewers on undertaking peer review and assessment of outputs.		Head of Research	Dec-24	Dec-24
		2.3 Ensure that all internal REF reviewers have completed the online module on bias in research assessment.		UOA Leadership Teams	Aug-24	Dec-24
		2.4 Review the criteria, tools and processes for all internal RKE funding competitions to ensure they align to CoARA commitments and use peer review to assess applications and make funding decisions.		RKE Manager	Jan-25	Ongoing
		2.5 Embed a narrative CV approach in the annual/interim review process, including delivery of training (see action 7.4).	Yes	Head of Research and Head of People & Development	Mar-24	Sep-24
		2.6 Review the staff recruitment process in line with CoARA. Consider implementing a statement/process around recruitment strategies for research-related roles and the primacy of qualitative evaluation.		Head of People & Development	Jan-26	Jul-26
		2.7 Improve the RKE Performance Reports to ensure inclusion of appropriate qualitative and quantitative information.		Head of Research and Professor of Musculoskeletal Health & Care	Sep-24	Ongoing
3	Core commitment: Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular, inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.	3.1 Review the application and decision-making processes for the Open Access Fund.		RKE Manager	Jan-25	Jul-25
		3.2 See action 1.2.				
4	Core commitment: Avoid the use of rankings for research organisations in research assessment.	4.1 Work with Marketing and Communications to ensure the use of rankings is made with consideration of the HSU Policy on Responsible Research Metrics.		Head of Research	Sep-25	Ongoing
5	Commit resources to reform research assessment as needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.	5.1 Establish the HSU CoARA Working Group as a coalition of internal stakeholders (including Library, Research Office, HR), researchers (all career stages) and an external advisor(s).		CoARA Working Group	Aug-24	Ongoing
		5.2 Commit to ensuring the Head of Research and RKE Manager have dedicated time and support to engage in the CoARA work, including the Boost Cascade project and the UK National Chapter work.		Vice-Chancellor	May-24	Ongoing
		5.3 Arrange for training on responsible research assessment for the CoARA Working Group.	Yes	Head of Research	Dec-24	Jan-25

No.	Commitment	Action	Part of CoARA award	Responsibility	Start	End
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes.	6.1 Evaluate the existing criteria, tools and procedures (PRPs/PPPPs and Academic Framework), using the SCOPE framework and the SPACE rubric. Engage the researcher community in this review, including the identification of options for developing existing and creating new criteria, tools and procedures.	Yes	CoARA Working Group	Jan-25	Feb-25
		6.2 Develop, design, pilot and evaluate a new approach for the annual/interim performance review exercise, ensuring the new approach is fair, robust, transparent and consistent. Engage the researcher community in this review, including the identification of options for developing existing and creating new criteria, tools and procedures.	Yes	CoARA Working Group	Mar-25	Apr-25
		6.3 Roll out the good practice from the pilot to the Academic Framework and associated processes, including promotions and recruitment.		CoARA Working Group	Jan-26	Aug-26
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.	7.1 Working with Marketing & Communications to develop and deliver a strong internal comms plan about our commitments to CoARA and DORA and our work to reform research assessment across the university.	Partially	CoARA Working Group	Nov-24	Ongoing
		7.2 Use the CoARA guiding principles and questions to structure engagement sessions with staff to help enhance the action plan.		Head of Research & RKE Manager	Jan-25	Ongoing
		7.3 Arrange training (including leadership development and research-specific bias training) for evaluators and research leaders as part of the pilot of the new annual/interim review process.	Yes	RKE Manager	May-25	Sep-25
		7.4 Arrange training for staff, e.g. on writing a narrative CV.	Yes	RKE Manager	May-25	Sep-25
		7.5 Develop a plan to engage the HSU Board of Governors, Executive Leadership Group, and Wider Management Group in the CoARA work (for example, a showcase event).		CoARA Working Group	Jun-25	Ongoing
8	Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.	8.1 As a member of the UK National Chapter, engage with its activities and promote membership to other institutions.		Head of Research & RKE Manager	May-24	Ongoing
		8.2 Working with the other members of the UK National Chapter, contribute to the work of the CoARA working Groups and share that work with other chapter members.		Head of Research & RKE Manager	May-25	Ongoing
		8.3 Engage with GuildHE Research and its members to promote and share experiences on the implementation of CoARA in small & specialist institutions.		Head of Research & RKE Manager	Nov-24	Ongoing
		8.4 Participate in the two CoARA Boost workshops in 2025.	Yes	Head of Research & RKE Manager	May-25	Dec-25
9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments.	9.1 Publish the HSU CoARA action plan on the University's website and Zenodo, and update regularly with a publicly visible RAG status against each major action.		Head of Research	Mar-25	Ongoing
		9.2 . Annually report on progress against the action plan to the HSU Research & Innovation Committee.		Head of Research	Aug-24	Ongoing



No.	Commitment	Action	Part of CoARA award	Responsibility	Start	End
10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence-gathering and research.	10.1 See action 8.2.				
		10.2 Participate in the People, Culture & Environment pilot exercise for REF 2029 and provide feedback on alignment to the CoARA principles, where appropriate.		REF Working Group	Oct-24	May-25
		10.3 Regularly share good practice in academic career assessment with colleagues internally.	Yes	Head of Research	Nov-24	Jan-25